autonomous processes moving in the same direction. They include the ambitions of China, the interests of India, the posture of Japan, the confidence of Australia and the awareness of the ASEAN. Like alliances, strategic concepts also respond to times and the moment of Indo-Pacific has arrived again.

As with many other developments in the world today, the trigger for Indo-Pacific too is the change in the American stance and the rise of China. Because the former is more reactive, it makes sense to centre analysis around the latter. A decade ago, China debated vigorously and publicly the role of maritime power in its future. Part of that was to address a traditional strategic dilemma posed by the limitations of its eastern seaboard and multiple island chains beyond. But by 2009, there was also a larger quest which subsumed this argument. Chinese policymakers had already recognized that if that nation was to emerge as a global power, it must perforce be a maritime one. The ensuing debate upended a historical tradition quite comprehensively. In that sense, 2012 was not just a transition in political leadership but in strategic thinking as well.

The impact of global developments on the Indian Ocean could not have left India unaffected. Its location jutting into the centre gives that country a unique attribute. This strategic edge was, however, taken so much for granted that its maritime exploitation was always below par. As greater naval activity unfolded, India also had to contend with connectivity initiatives that had maritime implications. This now meant an oceanic focus for a power whose security horizons were already being stretched. The nature of the challenge is also novel since so much of it is played out in the global commons. The solution to this predicament inevitably was in the strengthening of capability, creation of balances and encouragement of cooperation. It is logical for India to work with those who value its influence, advocate a larger role for it and are comfortable with its activities.

As each major power has its own perspective, their narratives sometimes can be different. For India, it is all about the pathway of its own steady rise, while also responding to the compulsions arising from the posture of others. The East Asia Summit already took India beyond the Indian Ocean to the